



Children's Tales

The Headwaters Collection

Nine complete tales from the Codetry story collection

HEADWATERS · CODETRY

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The Button She Almost Didn't Press

A tale about labour, patience, and the weight of meaning

Kaya had been inside for eleven days.

Not sick. Not grounded. Just — inside. The summer had gotten long in a way summers sometimes do when you're sixteen and there's nothing that needs you.

Her cousin was at her dad's in Thunder Bay. The community centre was doing little kids' programs. Everyone seemed to be somewhere that wasn't for her.

She opened the Helping Hands app the way you open the fridge when you're not hungry — just to see.

There was a section she'd never clicked: Skills. A list of things people in the community knew how to do. Beading. Bannock. Net repair. Chainsaw maintenance. Cree syllabics. And near the bottom, under Food and Harvest:

Wild Rice Harvesting.

She didn't know why she stopped there. She'd eaten wild rice her whole life. She'd never thought about where it came from, exactly. The lake. Obviously the lake. But she'd never been out there when it happened.

There was a small button beneath the description. It just said: I'm watching this.

She pressed it. Nothing happened. The screen didn't change. No confetti. No notification. She put her phone down and went back to watching the ceiling.

• • •

Four days later, Margaret Swain called her.

Kaya almost didn't answer. She didn't know Margaret well — she was an old woman who lived near the dock, the kind of person adults talked about with a certain respectful hush. She had a boat she'd been taking out alone for forty years.

I saw your name on the list, Margaret said. You want to learn the rice?

Kaya said yes before she understood what she was agreeing to.

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They went out the first morning before the sun was fully up.

The lake smelled like cold and green things. Margaret handed her a pole and showed her how to hold it — low, steady, moving from the hips, not the arms. They pushed through the rice beds in silence. The stalks were taller than Kaya expected, brushing against her arms, the grains hanging heavy at the top.

Not yet, Margaret said.

How do you know?

Pinch one. Rub it. Is it soft or does it hold?

Kaya tried. She didn't know what she was feeling for.

Soft, Margaret said. We wait.

They went out four mornings that week and came back each time without rice. Kaya learned to read the colour of the stalk. She learned how the grains sounded against each other when the wind came through — not ready, not ready, not ready. She learned that Margaret never seemed impatient, and that this was itself a kind of teaching.

On the fifth morning, Margaret reached up, rubbed a grain between her fingers, and looked at her.

Today, she said.



The ricing sticks were smooth from decades of use. Margaret showed her the motion — one stick to bend the stalk over the canoe, one to knock the grains loose. Gentle but decisive. You weren't hitting the rice, you were inviting it to fall.

At first Kaya was too hard. Rice scattered into the water.

Not like that, Margaret said. She didn't explain further. She just showed her again.

Kaya tried softer. More rice stayed. She found the rhythm slowly — bend, knock, bend, knock — the grains raining down into the hull in a sound she had never heard before and would not forget. Dry and full and alive.

Her arms ached by midmorning. Her back hurt in a new way. The mosquitoes found the gap between her collar and her hat. The sun came up and the lake got bright and she kept going because Margaret kept going, and stopping felt like the wrong answer to something, though she couldn't have said what the question was.



They worked through the morning until the canoe was heavy with it. The rice lay in the hull like small dark keys, thousands of them — all that waiting, now something real you could hold.

Margaret cut the engine on the way back and let them drift for a moment.

My grandmother showed me, she said. Hers showed her. It goes back further than either of us can name.

Kaya looked at the rice. She looked at her sore hands. She didn't say anything because there wasn't anything to say that would fit.



That night, opening the app to show her mom, Kaya noticed her name had moved. Under wild rice harvesting, where it used to say Watching, it now said Learning.

She wasn't sure how to explain what that meant. It was just a word on a screen.

But she'd been out on that lake. She'd waited when the rice said wait. She'd learned the knock that doesn't scatter. She'd come home with something real in the hull and something different in her chest — a kind of weight she'd been missing without knowing it.

She put her phone down.

Tomorrow, Margaret said, they would parch it.

There was more to learn.



In the Helping Hands skill directory, wild rice harvesting lives under Food and Harvest. Anyone can press I'm watching this. The Knowledge Holder who carries the skill sees your name. What happens after that has been happening on this lake for longer than the app — longer than the phones — longer than most of the words we have for it. The technology just made sure the door was easy to find.

Author note. *The Watching stage is the door before the door. No commitment, no test, no credentials. Just: I see this and I'm curious. Someone who holds something real sees your name. That thread — between a restless kid and a person with forty years in a boat — is what the system is actually for.*

The Girl Who Waited for the Eagle

A tale for children of all ages, on every kind of ground

There was once a girl who had too many ideas.

They came to her in the morning before she opened her eyes. They came to her in the river, in the shape of the current. They came to her in the market, watching the old women trade things that had no price tags — a jar of something, a word of something, a promise of something.

She wrote them all down. Thousands of them. Pages and pages of ideas that had no shape yet, only a direction.

What are they for? people would ask.

I don't know yet, she would say. But I will.

• • •

She had been watching eagles her whole life.

Not looking for them. Watching them. There is a difference. Looking is hoping something will come. Watching is being ready when it does.

Eagles do not come when you call. They come when you are ready for what they carry.

She had learned this the slow way.

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For years she walked into communities and told them what she thought she had.

Most listened politely. Some said interesting. None said yes.

She drove home on long roads and asked the sky: Is this the right direction?

The sky did not answer. Or maybe it did, and she was not yet ready to hear it.

• • •

Then one morning she was standing outside, writing in the early cold, and she asked herself the question again — the same question, worn smooth from so many years of asking.

Is this the right direction?

And an eagle appeared.

Not circling far away. Not a shape on the horizon. He came from nowhere and dropped low, and held himself above her in the wind — like he was reading her, the way she had spent years reading the land.

She said, Well, hello.

He stayed.

She asked again: Is this the right direction?

He rose in a slow circle — once, twice — and flew out of sight.

She stood still for a long time.

She understood that some questions take much longer to answer than you expect. And that the answer had already been yes — she just hadn't heard it yet.



Not long after, she found herself sitting in a small room with a very old woman.

The old woman's hands were the most knowledgeable thing about her. They moved when she talked, like they were drawing the story in the air before the words arrived.

The girl had been told: do not bring your ideas into this room. She had left them outside, in her bag, in the car.

She brought nothing but her ears.

The old woman talked for a long time about things that had no English words. She talked about how her people said enough in a way that also meant full and grateful. How they said trade in a way that also meant we are part of each other's story now. How they said home in a way that held the river, the season, the name of a grandmother, and a specific kind of light all at once.

The girl listened.

Then, very quietly, she asked: Would it be alright if I wrote some of these down?

The old woman looked at her for a long time.

Not yet, she said. Come back.



The girl came back. Again and again. Each time, she brought less. Each time, she was invited further in.

One afternoon the old woman said: The problem with your people's words is they sit still. Ours move. You can't put a moving word in a box.

What if the box moved with it? the girl said.

The old woman was quiet. Then she smiled.

Show me, she said.



And that was how the ledger began.

Not with an idea or a plan. Just an old woman saying show me — and a girl who had stopped talking and started listening.

The ledger was not a dictionary. It was not a translation. It was a living record — words in the shape they lived in that community, connected to the people who carried them, updated when the community said so, closed to the outside world unless the community opened it.

It belonged to them. She was only the one who had learned to hold it carefully.



She told her children about it at bedtime, years later.

What did the eagle mean? her youngest asked.

She thought about it.

I think he meant: you are slow enough now. You are ready.

Ready for what?

To be useful without being in charge of it.

Her child thought about this for a while.

That sounds hard, he said.

It is, she said. It takes about thirty years.

Author note. *A true story, told sideways.*

The eagle was real. The waiting was real. The old woman is still waiting to be found.

This work is for her.

The Girl Who Never Knew

A coming-of-age tale, told in decades

She was born with her heart already outside her chest.

Not broken — just worn on the outside, where everyone could see it. She didn't know this made her different. She thought that was simply how hearts worked.

She lived at the edge of the trees, where the yard gave way to roots and shadows and a deep kind of quiet. She brought wildflowers to the neighbours without being asked. She sat with the old dog next door when it was sick. She noticed, without being told, when someone was about to cry — and she would simply stay nearby, because being close was its own kind of help.

Her world was small. And in that smallness, it was full.

Her mother called her beautiful inside and out. She accepted this the way she accepted most things — warmly, without question. She didn't know, then, that not every girl heard those words.

She didn't know, then, what the world outside the trees was made of.

• • •

When she became a teenager, she pulled her circle tighter — not from fear, exactly, but from a kind of knowing.

She had found her nook. A corner of the forest that was hers to tend. She knew which mosses grew along the north-facing rocks, which paths stayed dry after rain, which branches held the best quiet. She kept it beautiful the only way she knew how: slowly, tenderly, a little at a time.

Her friends were few and chosen. Her joy was specific. She did not need much from the world because she had learned how to make enough from what was near.

Some people called this small.

She called it enough.

She didn't know, then, that enough can be a wall as much as a gift.

• • •

University took her to bigger rooms and louder voices. She moved through them quietly — always finding the calmer edges and the places where the noise didn't reach.

She was supposed to graduate on time. There was one course — a small one, taken online — that stood between her and the finish line. But it never quite arrived. The screen felt thin and far away, and outside the window there were always more beautiful things to look at. Always some reason to disappear back through the trees.

So when the calendar gave her one more semester and the chance to choose something of her own, she chose a course she couldn't explain. A program. A place. The heart of downtown Winnipeg, which might as well have been another country.

She was pulled there for reasons she couldn't name. A lot of reasons, none of them in words.

So she went.



The room was small — a relief. But the faces were unfamiliar, and that was a new kind of discomfort.

She sat the way she had always sat: with big ears and a tender heart. And she listened.

What she heard undid her.

These were people of all ages — some her parents' age, some younger than she expected. And one by one, in that room in the heart of the city, they opened their lives and let her look inside. Stories of things she had no word for. Experiences that her small and careful world had never once prepared her to hold.

She went home each night and cried herself quiet.

Not from sadness, exactly. From the rearranging.

Thirty days. Thirty days of a world she had not known was there — grey in the places she had always imagined as bright, and pitch black in corners that had never once occurred to her. People who had seemingly never, not once, felt warmth from the inside.

It tore her to pieces.

And then, slowly, it put her back together differently.

She didn't know, then, that this was the gift. That being broken open is how you make room for more.



Years later she would be sitting on a deck, watching the light go long across the yard, and she would think: that was the moment. That room. That city. Those thirty days. That was where the path turned.

She hadn't seen it clearly then. You never do.

But she would sit at a table, later still, and watch an old woman's hands — the way they moved without hurry, the way they held things gently, the way they had learned, over a long life, to carry what was heavy without letting it show.

And she would understand, finally, what she had been learning all along.

That a heart worn on the outside is not a weakness.

It is a kind of readiness.

She just never knew, until then, what she was ready for.

Author note. *Some rooms change you before you understand what happened inside them. The gift usually arrives looking like loss.*

The Fish Who Stopped Trying to Climb

On knowing what you were built for

She had been told her whole life that the ones who get somewhere are the ones who climb.

The heron said it from the top of the dead cedar. The osprey said it by going where she could not follow. The people on the bank showed it without words — they always looked up when they talked about the future, never down.

She was a small fish in a small creek. The creek ran cold and clear through the tamarack bog, past the old beaver dam, under the road, into the lake. It was a good creek. Everyone agreed it was too small.

Climb, they said. That is how you get somewhere.

• • •

She tried.

In June she flopped herself out onto the bank, gripped the roots of the cedar, and pulled. She got nowhere. The mud was soft and she fell back into the water breathing sideways.

She tried again in July. The mud was harder. She got higher — almost a body length up the root before she fell. She lay in the shallows a long time after that.

I am doing this wrong, she thought. I must be doing this wrong.

By August she had stopped trying at night. She lay in the deep cold beneath the beaver dam and looked up at the light rippling on the surface and told herself she would try again in the morning.

She didn't tell anyone she had stopped. It felt like something to be ashamed of.

• • •

In September the rains came hard.

In three days the creek rose over its banks. The water moved down through the tamaracks in a wide silver sheet, and she went with it — not choosing, just carried. She passed through the culvert. She passed through the shallows at the lake's edge. She passed through the cold seam where the creek water and the lake water met, and then she was somewhere she had never been.

She stopped trying to hold on.

The current knew where to go.



In two days she had seen more of the world than she had seen in her whole life.

She swam through the shadow of the osprey without being taken. She found the deep pool behind the boulder where the big trout rested in the heat of the day, and they moved aside without a word. She felt the place where a cold spring entered from below — icy cold in just a body length — and she understood, for the first time, that water came from somewhere. It came from deep in the ground. It had been there a long time before it found its way out.

She had swum down, not up.

And in the going down, she had found the whole river.



By October she could read the water the way some people read a map.

She knew which bends went dry in drought and which held the deep pools that never emptied. She knew the gravel bars where the sunlight reached and the shaded banks where it didn't. She knew the cold patches and the warm shallows and the places where the river looked fast but wasn't — and the places where it moved exactly as fast as it seemed.

She had not learned any of this from a teacher. She had learned it from being inside it.

The river gave her what the tree never could. Not a view from above. A knowledge from within.



One evening in late October a child sat on the bank above the deep pool. She was young — maybe eight — with a stick and a line and a look on her face like she had been sent here by someone and wasn't sure why.

The fish rose near the surface. Not to be caught. Just to see.

The child saw the fish. The fish saw the child. They stayed like that — still in the last of the light — for longer than either of them planned.

I don't know why I'm here, the child said. Not to the fish. Just to the water.

The fish turned and swam slowly upstream.

The child stood and followed along the bank, stepping through the tall grass, over the roots, around the beaver dam. The fish led in the water. The child followed on land. Neither of them spoke. They went together for a long time in the last light.

When they reached the cold spring, the fish circled twice.

The child knelt at the bank and put her hand in the water. It was cold and clean and came from deep in the ground, from somewhere old and dark and patient. It had been there longer than either of them. It would be there long after.

The child looked at the fish for a long moment.

Then she picked up a smooth stone from the bottom, put it in her pocket, and walked back the way she came. She didn't know what she was taking it home for.

That was all right.

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Some things don't need to be understood before they become yours.

• • •

The fish went back to the deep pool and rested.

She had not climbed anything.

She had gone where the water went, and found that the whole river was her home.

Author note. *The freedom was never up the tree. It was already in the current — the fish just had to stop trying to climb long enough to feel it. The things we have been told to want and the things we were built for are sometimes the same, and sometimes they are not. Learning to tell the difference is not a single moment of clarity. It is a whole river, moved through over time. The child takes a stone home without knowing why. That is how it works — the knowing comes later, if it comes at all. The going is enough.*

The Boy Who Counted the Rings

On learning that is not done to you

The tree came down in early December, after the ground had frozen hard enough to drag on.

His grandfather cut it — a white spruce, old and straight, taller than the barn — and when it fell it made a sound the boy felt in his chest. Then his grandfather walked to the stump, crouched down, and looked at it for a long time without saying anything.

The boy came and crouched beside him. The stump was wide — wider than his arms could reach — and the rings inside it ran close together in some places and far apart in others. He had learned in school that you could read the age of a tree in the rings. He waited for his grandfather to start reading.

His grandfather reached into his jacket and handed him a knife.

You count them, he said.

The boy looked at him. He had expected to watch. He had expected to be told.

Start at the outside and work in, his grandfather said. That's all.

Then he stood, went to the sled, and started cutting branches.

• • •

The boy knelt at the stump and pressed the blade lightly against the wood. The rings were thin near the outside — the last few years — and he traced each one with the tip of the knife, counting under his breath.

He lost count at thirty-one. Started again.

He lost count again at forty-something. The rings got blurry where they ran close together.

He pressed his thumb against the wood instead. He could feel the difference between the dense rings and the wide ones — the hard years and the easy years, though he did not know that yet in those words. He went slowly. He started to understand where one ring ended and the next began not by looking but by feeling, the way you learn a path in the dark.

He counted eighty-seven rings before he reached the center, where the wood was dark and tight.



His grandfather came back and looked over his shoulder.

Eighty-seven, the boy said.

His grandfather was quiet for a moment. He ran his own thumb along a stretch of close rings near the middle of the stump.

That was a dry spell, he said. Tree barely grew.

The boy looked at the tight rings and looked at the wide ones and suddenly he could read them — not every detail, but the shape of the story. The hard years narrow. The good years wide. The tree remembering every season it had ever been through, in the wood itself.

How did you know I could do it? the boy asked.

His grandfather picked up the knife and folded it closed and handed it back to him.

I didn't know, he said. But you did it anyway.



The boy kept the knife. He did not know yet what else it would open.



Eighty-seven years of weather, in the wood of a tree that fell on a December morning. You don't need to be told what that means. You just need to count it yourself.

Author note. *The lesson is not in the telling. It is in the doing before you feel ready — the knife in your hand before you asked for it, the counting that gets harder before it gets easier. A grandfather who explains robs the grandchild of the discovery. One who hands over the knife and walks away gives something that cannot be taught any other way.*

The Girl Who Stopped Waiting for Spring

On the aliveness that does not wait for permission

Every year she waited for the ice to break on the lake.

It happened in April, sometimes May. There was a sound to it — not a crack so much as a low, settling groan, like the lake was exhaling something it had held all winter. She had been hearing that sound her whole life and it still made her stop whatever she was doing and listen.

When the ice broke she felt like herself again. Full and awake and in the right place. She could not have explained it to anyone who asked.

The months between freeze and breakup — October through May — she spent in a kind of holding. Not unhappy. Not exactly. Just waiting. Keeping herself in reserve until the world said it was time.

• • •

One February, the hardest month, the one that showed no signs of ending, she was looking out the back window at the yard when she saw it.

A small push of green, coming up through the snow at the base of the fence.

She went outside in her coat and crouched down to look at it. The ground was still frozen six inches down. The temperature had not been above minus ten in three weeks. Whatever this was had no business being here. Nothing had said it could.

And yet.

• • •

She watched it for the next two weeks. Some mornings it was buried under new snow and she would find it again when the snow shifted — still green, still pushing, as if it had not gotten the message that this was not its season.

It did not ask if it was time. It did not look at the ice on the lake. It grew toward something it could not see yet, through ground that had not softened, in a month that gave it nothing to work with.

She started going outside in the mornings to check on it. She did not tell anyone. It was hers in a way she could not explain.



April came. The ice broke — she heard it, the same exhale — and she went to the lake the way she always did, and stood at the edge, and felt it: the fullness, the waking.

But this year it was different. This year she recognized it.

She had felt this in February, kneeling in the snow at the base of the fence. She had felt it every morning she went outside to check on the green thing that grew without permission. The feeling had not been stored away waiting for the ice. The feeling had been available the whole time. She just had not known to look for it before April.



The ice broke anyway.

But this year she was already there when it did.

Author note. *The aliveness that arrives with spring is real. But the capacity for it was never seasonal. It was only ever waiting for her to stop waiting. The February green that grows without permission is not a lesson — it's a reminder. The internal drive that needs an external cue to feel legitimate is still the drive. It just hasn't trusted itself yet.*

The Elder Who Sat at the Creek

On the kind of teaching that happens without a lesson

Every afternoon at the same time, the old woman walked down the slope behind the house and sat at the same place on the bank where the creek bent around the root of an old birch.

She brought nothing with her. She did not fish. She did not read. She sat and she looked at the water.

The children called it her resting time. They said it the way children say things they have learned from adults without understanding — with a careful respect that was mostly just caution. She heard them. She did not correct them.

• • •

The first child who came to sit beside her was the restless one — the one who couldn't be still anywhere else, who moved through every room like something was chasing her. She came and sat on the bank and lasted four minutes before she got up and left.

She came back the next day. She lasted six minutes.

The old woman said nothing. She watched the water.

• • •

By the end of the week the restless one was lasting twenty minutes, and she had stopped fidgeting by the third day. She was watching the place where the current split around the root that reached into the water — the way it went smooth on one side and rippled on the other. She watched it the way you watch something you are trying to understand.

Then the curious one came. Then two more. By midsummer there were often three or four children on the bank at any given afternoon, and the old woman among them, and no one speaking.

• • •

They began to see things.

The dragonfly that held still in moving air. The heron downstream who could stand in the current without shifting for twenty minutes at a time. The way the light hit the water differently in the hour before the sun went behind the tree line — everything going gold and then going quiet. The place on the far bank where the mink came every third day or so, so reliable you could set your afternoon by it.

They did not talk about what they saw. They just saw it.

• • •

One afternoon the curious one asked:

What are you looking for?

The old woman was quiet for a moment.

Nothing now, she said.

The child thought about this for a while.

What were you looking for before?

The same thing, the old woman said. Until I found it.

The child did not understand. She went home thinking about it.

• • •

A year later she was sitting at the same spot alone, a Saturday in March, the creek running high and cold with the melt. She had come without thinking about it, the way you go to a place your body knows.

She sat and looked at the water.

She was not looking for anything.

And then she understood.

• • •

You look until you stop looking. And then you see.

• • •

The old woman had not taught any of them anything. She had just shown them how to stay.

Author note. *The deepest teaching is not a curriculum. It is a posture — someone at the water's edge who has learned to be still and does not hide it. The children came because something in them recognized something in her. She didn't call them. She didn't explain. She just kept showing up at the same place at the same time. That is sometimes all that is needed.*

The Man Who Came Back with Empty Hands

On the freedom that was never somewhere else

He left at nineteen.

He didn't leave angry. He left the way you walk away from something you love and still cannot stay — with one hand still almost reaching back. He told himself he was going to find something. He did not know the name of it yet, but he was sure it was not here.

• • •

He worked construction in the city for two years. He was good at it. He made more money than he had ever seen and spent it on things that filled his hands for a week and then didn't.

He moved further. He tried other cities and other kinds of work. He drove long stretches of highway alone, which he had expected to feel like freedom, and which felt like something else — not bad, just not what the word had promised.

He made friends and lost track of them. He had nights that were exactly what he'd imagined, and mornings after those nights that were not. He tried to want what the people around him wanted. Sometimes he almost did.

• • •

He came back in January, twenty-six years old, in a truck that needed work, with less money than he'd left with and nothing to show for the years except the fact of having spent them.

He expected things to feel different when he pulled off the main road. They did not feel different. The bush came up on both sides the same way it always had. The sky was the same particular grey it got in January when the cloud sat low and the light went flat. The tracks in the driveway were his mother's, from the morning, already half filled in by the snow.

He sat in the truck for a few minutes before he went in.

• • •

His grandmother was at the kitchen table. She did not ask where he had been. She slid a bowl of soup across the table and went back to what she was doing.

He sat down and ate. The kitchen smelled the same as it always had — something about the wood and the stove and the particular cold that came in under the door in January. He hadn't known he remembered that smell until it was in his nose.



Later he walked down the slope to the creek behind the house. It was frozen solid, but he could hear it — moving water under the ice, the same low sound it made every winter. He had been hearing that sound his whole life and had not thought about it once in seven years.

He stood on the bank for a long time.

He had traveled looking for the feeling of being his own — of life belonging to him, of moving through the world on his terms. He had found it in pieces, in moments, and lost it again. He had chased it across a lot of geography without it getting any closer.

Standing at the frozen creek in January, empty-handed, he could feel it. Not arriving. Already here. It had been here the whole time. He had just been somewhere else.



The freedom he had been looking for was not a location.

It was a permission. And he had always had it.

He just hadn't known it was his to take until he had tried to find it somewhere else and failed.



He went back inside. His grandmother was still at the table.

Welcome home, she said.

He sat down.

He didn't know yet what came next. That was all right. He was here now. The creek was still running under the ice. The kitchen still smelled like itself.

That was a beginning.

Author note. *Some people have to leave to find out that what they were looking for was not a place. The leaving is not a mistake — it is part of the knowing. You cannot understand that the freedom was always yours until you have spent real time looking for it somewhere else and come home with empty hands. The empty hands are not a failure. They are what you bring back when you are finally ready to receive what was here the whole time.*

The Boy Who Swallowed the Stars

A Quantum Adventure for Big Thinkers and Their Families

Once upon a time, in a cozy house on Orbit Lane, lived a boy named Zander Starburst.

At almost twelve, Zander's brain was a blazing supernova of ideas. Rockets made of laughter. Time machines powered by dreams. Questions so big they made the ceiling feel too small.

"What happens to my energy when I die?" he asked one Tuesday.

"Can thoughts travel faster than light?" he wondered on Wednesday.

Zander's ideas burst out with enormous, wonderful energy.

His mom, Captain Gravity, loved him more than the whole Milky Way. She made sure he was developing well, eating healthy food, and that wild ideas didn't accidentally launch anyone into outer space. She kept the world steady and safe.

But sometimes Zander's ideas got so big and fast that Captain Gravity's eyes would widen. She would listen for a little while, and then the gravity between them would get heavy for them both — the kind of heavy that ends in everyone feeling squished.



Then one afternoon a small, sparkly creature appeared on the windowsill.

He had the tail of a squirrel, the eyes of someone who had read everything twice, and a tiny chalkboard under his arm that read: PROFESSOR QUARK — Quantum Squirrel, at your service.

"I have been watching your household," said Professor Quark, flipping his tail importantly. "You have a superposition problem. Both of you are right at the same time. Neither of you can tell."

"What do we do?" said Zander.

"Three things," said Professor Quark. "Very small. Very powerful. Shall I?"

Captain Gravity pulled up a chair. Zander sat on the floor. Professor Quark cleared his throat.



The first thing was the Wonder Bins.

A special set of stackable bins where every idea goes — the wild ones, the scary ones, the too-big-for-now ones. Mom can add her thoughts too. The bins collapse when they aren't being used and stack neatly on top of each other. Each bin has a transparent envelope label so they can slip in a short project description or title. Nothing gets crushed. Everything stays possible and clearly named.



The second thing was Quantum Table Time.

Fifteen minutes every day where Zander gets to shine like a full star, and Mom gets to share her gravity wisdom — with no interruptions. They simply listen and say: What I heard is...

At any point in the day when they aren't seeing eye to eye, either one can stop the discussion and say: Put it on the Quantum Table. Zander is responsible for building his case privately and bringing it to their daily Quantum Table Time. If a decision isn't made in that time, it gets gently bumped to the next day's.



The third thing was the Strategic Collapse Menu.

When it's time to decide, they don't collapse into a boring YES or NO. They pick from:

Tiny Safe Test Version

Mix-Master Version (best of both ideas)

Keep Wondering Longer

Transform-It Twist!

"Nothing collapses until you choose how," said Professor Quark. "That is the quantum way."



The next afternoon, Zander put his Indoor Sky City with Trampoline Clouds idea into the Wonder Bins. Mom added her worries about safety and mess. Then they did their first Quantum Table Time.

For the first time in weeks, no one got squished.

Together they chose a Tiny Safe Test Version: a pillow fort with glow-stick stars and one small trampoline.

It was ridiculous. It was glorious. Zander laughed so hard he almost floated.



Even the biggest questions — the ones about energy and death and light — went into the Wonder Bins now. Sometimes Mom added a thought. Sometimes they sat with them at Quantum Table Time and just named what they didn't know yet.

That turned out to be enough. More than enough.

Their new words spread through the house like starlight:

"Superposition time!" or "Put it on the Quantum Table!"

And instead of becoming a black hole, Zander and Captain Gravity became a double star system — two bright, strong lights orbiting each other, sharing energy instead of stealing it.



Zander still had enormous ideas.

Mom still kept him safe.

But now their love had room to grow without collapsing.

And somewhere in the quantum playground, Professor Quark the Quantum Squirrel gave a satisfied little flip of his sparkly tail.



The End... (or one of many wonderful possible beginnings!)

Author note. Every big idea needs a safe place to land. The Wonder Bins, the Quantum Table, the Strategic Collapse Menu — these aren't just for children. Any two people trying to share a life without crushing each other's light could use a system for holding ideas gently. The pillow fort was the point all along.